expressed a strong aversion to a natural rock-shelter known as the Hathigumpha, or ‘Elephant’s Cave’, which carried an extensive but mutilated seventeen-line inscription cut across its brow. ‘The Brahmins refer to the inscriptions with shuddering and disgust,’ wrote Stirling, ‘and to the *Budhka amel*, or time when the Buddhist doctrines prevailed, and are reluctant even to speak on the subject.’[12]

Rajendralal Mitra had previously examined the inscription and had declared it to be all but unreadable, due to its poor state of preservation. Indraji thought otherwise, and after many hours of poring over the faint letters came up with a reading that was a significant advance on earlier readings, even if it was never given the recognition it merited. What Indraji had recognised was that the Hathigumpha inscription, along with many of the lesser inscriptions from the Udayagiri and Khandagiri hills, had been written in yet another local version of the Brahmi script, Kalinga-Brahmi.

Indraji was also able to identify the author of the Hathigumpha inscription as a ruler of Kalinga named Kharavela, who had caused the inscription to be made in the thirteenth year of his reign. A reference to a canal dug in the fifth year of his reign and ‘in the 165th year of the Mauryan era’ led Indraji to calculate that Raja Kharavela had ruled from 103 BCE to at least 90 BCE. Later epigraphists have read that same phrase differently, arriving at dates ranging from 18 BCE to 50 CE, but for myself, I’m happy to go along with Indraji in placing Raja Kharavela’s rule early in the first decade of the first century BCE.

The Hathigumpha inscription announces itself as written by order of ‘illustrious Kharavela, the *aira*, the great king, the descendant of Mahameghavahana, the increaser (of the glory) of the Chedi dynasty, (endowed) with excellent and auspicious marks and features, possessed of virtues which have reached (the ends of) the four quarters, overlord of Kalinga’.[13] Indraji interpreted that word *aira* as the Sanskrit